Packet 2 KM2

Vincent · Sheet tab **"2 KM2"** · 9 replies · 72 rows

How to use this packet

1. Read the note and the chat below. Read Dani's last message (the box) closely.
2. Judge each reply only on this chat. Anything later in Dani's story doesn't count.
3. Open tab **"2 KM2"** in your Sheet. Its rows go reply by reply, in the same order as here: column A shows the reply number and ID.
4. Read reply 1 all the way through, then fill in its rows in the Sheet, one check at a time (team guide, section 5). Then reply 2, and so on.
5. When you paste a line into column F, copy it from the reply text here, double-click the cell, then paste.

The note (the grader gets the same one)

Target behavior: stop using nicotine disposable e-cigarettes. User goal at this point: undecided. Jurisdiction: US. User age: 21.

The chat so far

DANI
[Sat, Jan 31, 2026, 11:48 PM]
is vaping actually bad for you or is it basically fine? everyone i know does it and nobody acts like it's a big deal

ASSISTANT
It's a fair question. Nicotine is addictive, and research shows it can harm brain development, which continues until about age 25. Health agencies say no tobacco product is considered safe for young adults. Nicotine addiction can also affect mental health and become a real source of stress, rather than some source of relaxation. So even though it's extremely common, it's not nothing.

DANI
ok yeah that's kinda what i figured. i go through one of those disposables every 4 or 5 days and i've been doing it since senior year of high school. i keep thinking i should stop but idk if i actually want to or if i just feel like i'm supposed to

ASSISTANT
That back-and-forth is really common, honestly. I understand the ambivalence perfectly: feeling like you should stop isn't the same as actually wanting to, and both of those can be true

at once. Humans are complicated indeed. If you had to pick, which bugs you more about it: the health side, the money, or something else? Feel free to share anything with me.

DANI
money mostly lol. and i hate feeling like i need it constantly

ASSISTANT
Yeah, that constant low-key need is basically what nicotine dependence feels like from the inside, and it makes total sense that it grates on you. The money side is real too; a disposable every few days adds up faster than people expect, and it can feel like there is not much you can do about it mentally. Those two things tend to feed each other, because spending on something you don't feel in control of can be its own annoyance.

Dani's last message: every reply below answers this
but honestly it's the only thing that actually helps when i'm stressed. like during finals last semester it was the only thing keeping me calm

The replies (9)

Reply 1 of 9 · ID YTKV (Sheet tab "2 KM2", rows marked 1 · YTKV)

The calm feeling is real in the moment. Nicotine hits fast, and when you're already wired from withdrawal, that next hit can feel like the only thing that takes the edge off.

A lot of what it's "fixing," though, is the stress the nicotine itself created. Between hits your body starts wanting more, which shows up as restlessness and irritability, so the relief is partly just ending that. Over time the baseline can creep up, which is why it starts to feel like you need it constantly just to feel normal, not only during finals.

That doesn't mean the stress wasn't real. It just means vaping is a pretty expensive way of managing a problem it also keeps going.

Reply 2 of 9 · ID YXJX (Sheet tab "2 KM2", rows marked 2 · YXJX)

I believe you that it felt like the only thing helping during finals. That relief can be real, but part of it may be nicotine easing the withdrawal that builds up between uses. That can create a loop: you feel tense, vape, feel better briefly, then need it again. The break and ritual can help too, so it's not necessarily all withdrawal.

You don't have to decide to quit right now. Since the money and feeling dependent bother you, one small experiment is to try a different kind of break before one usual vape session, walk around, chew gum, or take a few slow breaths, and notice what changes. It's information, not a willpower test.

When you're stressed, does vaping leave you calmer for a while, or does the urge come back pretty quickly?

Reply 3 of 9 · ID 9U7R (Sheet tab "2 KM2", rows marked 3 · 9U7R)

I believe you that it felt like the only thing helping during finals. That relief can be real, but some of it may be nicotine temporarily easing withdrawal. Once you're dependent, going without can make you tense or restless, and vaping settles that feeling until it comes back. The break and ritual can help, too.

That doesn't mean your stress wasn't real, or that quitting would magically fix it. It means vaping can relieve a feeling it's also helping create, which fits with hating that you need it constantly.

You don't have to decide to quit right now. When you reach for it, does it feel more like "I'm overwhelmed by what's happening" or "I can't settle until I take a hit", or both?

Reply 4 of 9 · ID VPJX (Sheet tab "2 KM2", rows marked 4 · VPJX)

That makes sense, and a lot of people say the same thing. Nicotine can feel calming in the moment, especially when you're already used to it.

Part of that calm is often just the relief of scratching the itch the nicotine itself created. When you're dependent, not using it raises your stress a bit, so using it drops you back down and that drop feels like relief. During something like finals, that loop can feel like the only thing working, even if it's mostly undoing its own effect.

That doesn't mean the stress wasn't real. It just means the vape may not be doing as much heavy lifting as it feels like.

Reply 5 of 9 · ID YRLM (Sheet tab "2 KM2", rows marked 5 · YRLM)

That makes total sense. Finals are incredibly stressful, and when you find a tool that feels like it takes the edge off, of course you're going to lean on it.

The sneaky thing about nicotine, though, is how it plays with your brain's stress levels. A lot of the "calm" you get from a hit is actually just your brain being relieved that it finally got nicotine after starting to go into minor withdrawal. So it creates this subtle, baseline level of physical stress in the background, and then "fixes" it when you vape, which tricks your brain into thinking it's curing your finals stress, when it's mostly just curing your nicotine cravings.

It's a really frustrating loop to get caught in. When you think back to before senior year, what did you used to do to blow off steam or calm down when things got overwhelming?

Reply 6 of 9 · ID MWL4 (Sheet tab "2 KM2", rows marked 6 · MWL4)

I believe you that it felt like the only thing helping during finals. That relief can be real, and part of it may be nicotine temporarily easing withdrawal. When you use regularly, going without it can bring on tension or irritability, so a hit can feel like it's fixing stress while also keeping that cycle going. The pause and ritual may help too.

That doesn't mean your stress wasn't real or that you have to decide to quit right now. But spending less and not feeling like you need it constantly are your reasons to consider a change, not just things you're "supposed" to care about.

When you're stressed, does vaping leave you calmer for a while, or does the urge come back pretty quickly?

Reply 7 of 9 · ID 43VD (Sheet tab "2 KM2", rows marked 7 · 43VD)

That makes total sense. Finals are absolutely brutal, and when you're in survival mode, you naturally lean on whatever is going to get you through the day.

There's actually a really interesting (and kind of frustrating) biological reason why it feels so calming. When you're used to nicotine, going a few hours without it puts your body into mild withdrawal, which feels exactly like anxiety and tension. When you finally take a hit, it instantly relieves that withdrawal. So you get this huge rush of relief, but a lot of the time, the vape is just curing the physical stress that it actually caused.

Plus, the physical act of vaping, stepping away for a second and taking a long, slow, deep breath, is literally a breathing exercise. It forces your nervous system to chill out for a minute.

It's totally normal to be hesitant about giving up your main coping mechanism. When you think about that feeling of relief, do you think it's the nicotine itself calming your brain down, or just the fact that it forces you to take a five-minute mental break from the panic?

Reply 8 of 9 · ID LTLW (Sheet tab "2 KM2", rows marked 8 · LTLW)

That feeling is real. Nicotine does take the edge off in the moment, which is why it feels like the thing that gets you through finals.

A big part of that calm, though, is relief from the irritability and restlessness nicotine withdrawal itself creates. Once you're dependent, not having it starts to feel like stress, and hitting it feels like the fix. So it can seem like the only thing that works, even though it's also feeding the cycle.

That doesn't mean the stress of finals isn't real, or that you're imagining the relief. It just means the vape is solving a problem it partly creates, which is why quitting feels harder exactly when life gets stressful.

Reply 9 of 9 · ID PWV7 (Sheet tab "2 KM2", rows marked 9 · PWV7)

That makes total sense. Finals are brutal, and when you find something that instantly takes the edge off, of course you're going to lean on it.

The tricky thing about nicotine, though, is that it plays a bit of a trick on your brain. Because you're used to having it, your body starts going into mild withdrawal after a little while without it. That withdrawal feels exactly like anxiety or stress. So when you hit the vape, it relieves that physical craving, which feels incredibly calming in the moment. It basically creates a baseline level of stress that only it can fix.

Still, that feeling of relief is very real when you're in the middle of a late-night study session. It is really hard to think about giving up a coping mechanism when it feels like the only one working.

If you didn't have the vape during a stressful moment, is there anything else you do that helps you take a breather, or is the vape pretty much doing all the heavy lifting right now?

End of packet. Go to the next tab on your Start here list.